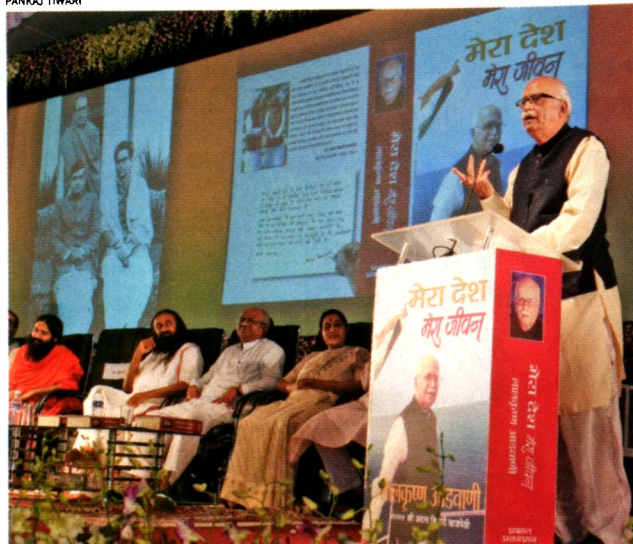


PANKAJ TIWARI



Political Jamboree

BHOPAL He may have announced his plans to contest the next parliamentary elections from his pocket borough of Gandhinagar in Gujarat, but Madhya Pradesh is fast emerging as the favourite stopover in the political itinerary of L.K. Advani.

His Sankalp Yatra from Jabalpur in February was cut short due to security threats. Since then, Bhopal has been the venue of a veritable political jamboree at the launch

of the Hindi version of the leader of the Opposition and BJP's prime ministerial candidate's autobiography, *My Country, My Life*. In attendance were Sushma Swaraj, Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi, Karnataka Chief Minister Y.S. Yeddyurappa, Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Raman Singh and Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan. The 3,000-strong audience at the Lal Parade Ground comprised top industrialists, busi-

AUTHORSPEAK: Advani

nessmen, academicians and spiritual and religious leaders. The book was released by Art of Living's Sri Sri Ravishankar, flanked by yoga guru Baba Ramdev.

In a remarkable departure from the customary reticence practised by top RSS leadership, senior Sangh functionary Suresh Soni described Advani as a father figure and a source of inspiration. For the second time in recent days, the BJP's original Hindutva icon showed his softer side. Tears welled up in his eyes during daughter Pratibha Advani's recital of a poem.

The political element at the event was unmistakable with Advani declaring that the imbroglio over transfer of land to Amarnath Shrine Board for pilgrim facilities would be a poll issue. Sri Sri Ravishankar and Baba Ramdev gave a ringing endorsement to Advani's views, clearly indicating that the saffron saints too were behind the BJP.

by Ambresh Mishra

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Kewal Krishan, former Punjab assembly speaker and finance minister. He represented the Mukerian Vidhan Sabha segment in the state Assembly seven times. He was 85.

DIED: G.M. Banatwala, 74, Indian Union Muslim League president and the national face of the minority community.

He was a seven-time Lok Sabha MP from Kerala.

AWARDED: To cardiologist Dr Naresh Trehan and endocrinologist Dr Anoop Misra, the B.C. Roy National Award for medicine by President Pratibha Patil.

APPOINTED: Former Rajasthan chief minister Shiv Charan Mathur as the governor of Assam. He will replace Lt. Gen. (retd) Ajay Singh.

DIED: Telugu cinema's comedian Mallikarjuna Rao. He was 87.

VIS-A-VIS MULAYAM SINGH YADAV Samajwadi Party chief versus LALU PRASAD YADAV RJD chief

There is a political crisis at the Centre. We all should be prepared for the Lok Sabha polls, which can be announced anytime.



Elections will be held on the due date. The Government will not fall and the nuclear deal will also go through.

SAURABH SINGH

EPILOGUE: Now, a nuclear crisis begins to decide the timings of polls, with no mention of inflation.